



The Morning Brief

MAY 17, 2026

Catalyst Week

NVDA earnings, the Warsh-era FOMC minutes, and the Iran strikes window all converge midweek as the NEE-Dominion talks land on Monday's tape.

S&P 500 (FRI CLOSE)	BRENT CRUDE (FRI CLOSE)	NEE (FRI CLOSE)	BITCOIN (LIVE)	FEAR & GREED
\$739.17 · ↓1.20% Fri · ↑~0.3% wk	~\$109 · ↑8.1% on week	\$93.36 · Dominion deal report	~\$78,200 · Below recent range	27 · Deeper Fear (from 31 Sat)

SECTION 01

Markets — Sunday Setup

A SEQUENCED WEEK IS SETTING UP — MONDAY MAY OPEN TO AN NEE–DOMINION DEAL HEADLINE, THEN A WEDNESDAY TRIPLE OF NVDA EARNINGS, FOMC MINUTES, AND THE IRAN STRIKES WINDOW CARSON’S SATURDAY BRIEF FLAGGED

Sunday’s setup reads as the lowest-volatility window between three sequential, high-magnitude catalysts. Per Bloomberg and the Financial Times via Investing.com on May 16, NextEra Energy is in talks to acquire Dominion Energy in a mostly stock combination that could be announced as early as Monday, with a Benzinga readout citing roughly \$400 billion in combined enterprise value were a deal to materialize. Wednesday, May 20 then layers NVDA’s fiscal Q1’27 print after the close on the FOMC minutes release at 1:00 PM CT — the first minutes of Kevin Warsh’s tenure as Fed Chair following his Senate confirmation Wednesday per CNBC and CBS coverage. The geopolitical clock is running in parallel: the New York Times reporting carried by The Times of Israel and Haaretz indicates Israeli and US preparations for renewed Iran strikes targeting readiness as soon as the upcoming week. Fear & Greed compressed further to 27 (Fear) per the data drop, from 31 Saturday and 43 last Thursday per prior briefs; Bitcoin trades near \$78,200 in weekend tape per CoinGecko, below the recent trading range. The IOWN portfolio is positioned across each of these axes — NEE in the dividend sleeve, NVDA/TSM/MRVL in growth, and the CVX/VLO/OKE energy block as the structural geopolitical hedge.

WED MAY 20 · TRIPLE CATALYST	NVDA fiscal Q1'27 AMC · FOMC Minutes 1:00 PM CT (Warsh era) · ADI pre-market
MON MAY 18 · NEE-DOMINION	Bloomberg/FT report combined enterprise value ~\$400B · Announcement possible Monday
FED CHAIR TRANSITION	Warsh confirmed 54–45 (closest modern era) · First FOMC June 16–17 per Fed calendar
S&P 500 · BRENT (FRI CLOSE)	\$739.17 ↓1.20% Fri / ↑~0.3% wk · Brent ~\$109 ↑8.1% wk per Reuters/Trading Economics
BITCOIN (LIVE SUN)	~\$78,200 per CoinGecko · Below recent trading range
FEAR & GREED	27 · Deeper Fear (from 31 Sat / 43 Thu)
CARSON'S ACTIVE LEVEL	SPY \$645.80 support · Untested (Friday low \$737.96 — ~12.6% above)

THE WARSH-ERA FOMC MINUTES ARRIVE INTO A COMMITTEE CARRYING THREE DISSENTS AND THE TAPE'S FIRST GENUINE HIKE-RISK REPRICING IN THIS CYCLE

Per CNBC and CBS coverage of the May 13 confirmation, Kevin Warsh was sworn in as Fed Chair following what

CNBC and Bloomberg characterized as the closest Senate vote in the modern era and inherits an FOMC carrying three dissents from the prior meeting. Per CNBC's post-PPI repricing coverage, futures markets now imply roughly 98% probability of no change at the June 16–17 meeting and approximately 37% odds the next move is a hike rather than a cut; BofA Global Research has pushed its first cut forecast to 2027 per TheStreet. Per The Motley Fool and Yahoo Finance coverage of Warsh's record, his historical posture has been hawkish on inflation credibility, with recent commentary characterized as incrementally more dovish than his first Board tenure. Wednesday's minutes will be parsed for dissent language, the staff inflation path, and any signal on the inflation-versus-credibility balance under the new chair. For the IOWN framework, the dividend spine (ABT, CL, NEE, GD, ATO, ADP, SYK) and the physical-AI growth bucket (CVX, VLO, OKE, NVDA, TSM, MRVL) are the positioning that tends to perform in a sticky-inflation, higher-for-longer rate regime; the structure was built for this scenario rather than against it.

Sunday is the quiet before three catalysts: a potential Monday utility megadeal in our dividend sleeve, then a Wednesday triple of NVDA earnings, the first Warsh-era FOMC minutes, and the reported Iran strikes window. The portfolio architecture aligns with each axis. Research Reveals Opportunities.

Geopolitics

THE IRAN DIPLOMATIC WINDOW HAS NARROWED FURTHER OVER THE WEEKEND — SUNDAY TALKS STALLED, TRUMP CHARACTERIZED THE CEASEFIRE AS “LIFE SUPPORT,” AND IRAN’S STOCK MARKET REOPENS TUESDAY IN A SIGNAL OF DOMESTIC REGIME CONTINUITY

The dominant weekend storyline remains the Iran trajectory. Per CBS News Sunday coverage citing UN Ambassador Mike Waltz on Fox News Sunday, the United States laid out what was characterized as a “very clear red line” in its latest proposal; Tehran has responded but Trump separately characterized the reply as totally unacceptable per Reuters and NBC. Per CNN, NPR, and PBS coverage of the past several days, the ceasefire in place since April 8 is described by Trump as on “life support,” with the sticking points reported by Al Jazeera and NBC as Iranian sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz, sanctions relief, and the absence of nuclear concessions in Tehran’s latest offer. The May 16 New York Times reporting carried by The Times of Israel and Haaretz that Israel and the US are in the most intense preparations since April’s ceasefire — with options including ground commandos to extract nuclear material or seize Kharg Island per US officials cited in the reporting — remains the binary catalyst that would override the other midweek items. Per Reuters reporting carried in the data drop headlines, Iran’s stock market is scheduled to reopen Tuesday after suspension; the resumption signals the regime’s posture of domestic continuity even as the operational picture tightens. The Israeli military separately announced new strikes on Hezbollah targets in southern Lebanon Sunday per CBS, with the Lebanon death toll in the conflict approaching 3,000 per the Lebanese Ministry of Public Health.

THE OIL MARKET SITS WITH ~4 MILLION BPD OF EMBEDDED UNDERSUPPLY, THE US TREASURY LET THE RUSSIAN OIL WAIVER EXPIRE THIS WEEK, AND THE STRAIT REMAINS EFFECTIVELY CLOSED — IOWN’S ENERGY SLEEVE CAPTURED FRIDAY’S ASYMMETRY

The structural energy backdrop has tightened along three vectors. Per the IEA monthly report cited by Trading Economics, crude and fuel flows through Hormuz fell by approximately 4 million bpd in March and April, and the agency now warns the global market may remain materially undersupplied through October even if the conflict resolves next month. Per Reuters via the data drop headlines, the US Treasury allowed its Russian oil waiver to expire amid crude back around \$100, removing one of the marginal supply taps in the official channel. CNBC’s coverage flags that global oil stockpiles could approach record lows if Hormuz remains closed. Per the House of Commons Library and UANI tracking data referenced in Saturday’s brief, open transits through the Strait have run near zero per day since May 6 versus roughly 138 vessels daily pre-crisis. Brent crude closed Friday around \$109 per Reuters and Trading Economics — the data drop’s BNO ETF closed at \$57.69 (+2.63%) and USO at \$148.23 (+3.66%). The IOWN energy sleeve captured the

move: CVX +2.39% to \$191.10, VLO +2.44% to \$250.74, and OKE +1.42% to \$92.32, with XLE +2.36% the lone winning sector Friday. Defense exposure via LMT and GD provides the orthogonal hedge if escalation operationalizes.

SUNDAY DIPLOMATIC STATUS	Tehran reply called unacceptable per Reuters · Ceasefire “life support” per Trump (NPR/PBS) · US “clear red line” per CBS
OPERATIONAL WINDOW	NYT/Times of Israel/Haaretz: most intense prep since April ceasefire · Readiness as early as this coming week
IRAN EQUITY MARKET	Scheduled reopen Tuesday per Reuters · Signal of regime continuity
HORMUZ TRANSIT	~0/day since May 6 vs ~138/day pre-crisis per Commons Library/UANI
IEA WARNING	Market may remain materially undersupplied through October even if conflict resolves next month
US TREASURY · RUSSIAN OIL WAIVER	Allowed to expire amid \$100 crude pressure per Reuters via data drop
IOWN ENERGY (FRI)	CVX ↑2.39% · VLO ↑2.44% · OKE ↑1.42% · XLE ↑2.36% (lone winning sector)

On Our Radar

1. Week Ahead — Monday opens to a potential NEE–Dominion announcement; the deal would reshape the IOWN dividend sleeve’s most strategic AI-infrastructure holding. Per Bloomberg and the Financial Times (via Investing.com) on May 16 and Benzinga’s follow-on coverage, NextEra Energy is in advanced discussions to acquire Dominion Energy in a mostly stock combination that could be announced as soon as Monday, with the reporting describing a combined enterprise of roughly \$400 billion. Dominion’s Virginia and Carolinas footprint anchors what is widely described as the country’s primary data-center corridor; NextEra is Florida-based and would gain direct exposure to the AI-driven power demand that the IOWN thesis (“physical world matters”) was constructed around. NEE closed Friday at \$93.36 (–2.42%) ahead of the Bloomberg/FT publication. Per the same coverage, the talks remain ongoing and could still collapse; antitrust and federal/state energy regulators would each need to approve. The strategic logic is consistent with the broader physical-AI infrastructure thesis that runs from chips (NVDA, TSM, MRVL) through power (NEE, VST, EIX) to midstream (OKE) — if announced, this is the largest articulation of the build-out yet. *Think Like an Owner.*

2. Wednesday’s triple is the binary core of the week — NVDA prints after the close, the Warsh-era FOMC minutes release at 1:00 PM CT, and IOWN’s ADI also reports. Per Tipranks, Benzinga, and The Motley Fool previews, NVDA fiscal Q1’27 consensus is approximately \$1.77 EPS on revenue near \$78.8–\$79.0 billion; analyst expectations cluster around forward Q2 guidance of approximately \$87 billion per The Motley Fool. Polymarket prices the beat probability at roughly 97% per The Motley Fool and 24/7 Wall St. coverage — the bar for upside surprise is now structurally elevated. The setup matters: NVDA closed Thursday at a record \$235.74 (+4.39%) on the H200 approval headline, then gave back 4.42% Friday to \$225.32. Per Benzinga and the May 15 brief, Beijing has separately guided Chinese firms to hold off on H200 purchases pending domestic alternatives; the print will test whether the China-thaw narrative converts to backlog visibility. Commentary on Blackwell ramp, Rubin timing, and hyperscaler capex will set the tone for the broader complex (MRVL, TSM, CRDO, AMD, LRCX). ADI closed Friday at \$417.49 (–2.18%) per the data drop and reports pre-market Wednesday per Stocktitan — its print is the IOWN dividend sleeve read-through on industrial and auto semi demand. *Research Reveals Opportunities.*

3. The Iran strikes window the May 16 brief flagged remains the catalyst that overrides everything else — Iran's stock market reopening Tuesday is the regime's public posture, the NYT-reported operational picture is the asymmetric tail.

If the May 16 New York Times reporting carried by The Times of Israel and Haaretz holds, operations could initiate during the upcoming week. The base case for energy markets had been a gradual diplomatic resolution; the renewed-strikes scenario inverts that base case. An operation against Kharg Island would compound the IEA's ~4 million bpd embedded undersupply rather than relieve it per Trading Economics. The IOWN sleeve's structural energy exposure (CVX, VLO, OKE, CTRA, CNX) was constructed to participate in this type of supply-shock asymmetry; defense exposure via LMT and GD provides the orthogonal hedge. Brent at approximately \$109 Friday close per Reuters/Trading Economics already reflects elevated risk premium; a further leg would depend on whether the diplomatic track collapses or the operational track moves first. *Avoid Erosion.*

4. Carson's active SPY support at \$645.80 remains untested with Friday's low at \$737.96 — the index sits roughly 12.6% above the retracement target as Fear & Greed

compresses to 27. The retracement framework set on April 13 remains intact and unhit; Friday's session preserved the structural cushion at roughly the same magnitude as Thursday (~12.6%). Fear & Greed at 27 (Fear) is the lowest reading in the recent sequence, down from 31 Saturday, 43 last Thursday, and 34 last Wednesday per prior briefs — the divergence between sentiment and index level has widened further. The retail-direct exposure inside the growth sleeve gave back Friday (HOOD -4.41% to \$77.14, COIN -7.82% to \$195.43, MARA -6.40%, HUT -6.31%) consistent with the broader risk-off; the digital ETF sleeve also gave back (IBIT -2.92%, ETHA -3.46%). Bitcoin trades near \$78,200 in weekend tape per CoinGecko, below the recent trading range. The Carson level continues to function as the meaningful downside reference if the strikes-binary or hike-risk scenarios materialize in the same window. **The physical world matters.**

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